

Leicestershire connections with the London Virginia Company

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Research into the origins and identities of the investors in the London Virginia Company that existed from 1607 until 1624, led to the identification of a number of Leicestershire connections with the first permanent English settlement in North America (the Jamestown settlement of 1607), and with the Virginia Company of the early years of the seventeenth century.

Background to the Virginia Company

On 10th April 1606 King James I issued a patent founding a Royal Council for Virginia. Its purpose was to explore and establish a colony in North America. This followed on from various earlier attempts from 1578 onwards to colonise the unoccupied lands north of the modern Florida and north of the then Spanish area of influence in the New World. (1)

The 1606 patent covered all territory between latitudes 34° to 45° North (2), in today's geography everything from the Carolinas to Maine. Those willing to participate in and fund the new venture formed themselves into two separate

groupings: those based in London, and a second group largely from Plymouth and the West Country. The London group were to concentrate on the southern part of the territory, whilst the Plymouth group would look to the northern part. However, the Plymouth group soon faltered after just one unsuccessful attempt at settling the Kennebec River estuary (present-day Maine) in 1607-8, being overcome by the harsh winter climate. Meanwhile, the London Group laid down the foundations for what was to become the first permanent English settlement in North America.

On 19th December 1606 three small ships, *the Susan Constant* (100 tons), *Godspeed* (40 tons) and *Discovery* (20 tons), left Blackwall and eventually reached the site that was to become Jamestown in May 1607. Estimates of the numbers on board the three ships vary from between 120 and 143, though only 104 appear to have actually reached their destination on the James River. This apparent discrepancy is probably resolved by Price's more recent tally of 105 colonists and 39 crewmen. (3)



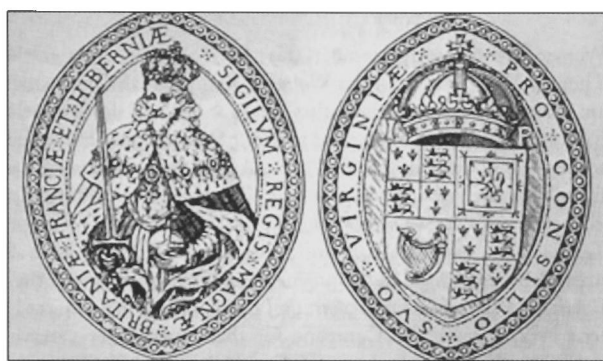
A replica of the Discovery is now moored at West India Quay, London Docklands adjacent to the Museum of Docklands. It was formally handed to the Museum by the present Governor of Virginia, the Hon. Timothy Kane on 19th December 2006, 400 years to the day of the embarkation of the first settlers.

The affairs of the Virginia colony were run by a special council appointed by the King. The council, or Company as it became known, nominated the on-site leaders of the new venture. The Company was obligated to hand over to the Crown a fifth of any precious metals that were discovered, but was granted certain local revenue raising powers for a period of twenty-one years. Among the Council were influential figures such as Sir Robert Cecil, though the 1606-7 expedition was largely financed by a small group of individuals, chief of them being Edward-Maria Wingfield, who travelled with the first voyage and became the first leader of the new colony. He proved to be most unsuited to the role and returned home effectively bankrupt leaving the fledgling colony struggling for survival. Another major backer and leader, and relative of Wingfield, Bartholomew Gosnold, was one of several fever victims in August 1607. The whole enterprise was soon showing signs of being severely under-funded. Consequently, drastic action was required and a second Charter was drawn up in 1609.

The new corporation took the grandiose title of the Treasurer and Company of the Adventurers and Planters for the City of London for the first colony of Virginia (4) and under the terms of this Second Charter of April 1609, shareholders

were invited to subscribe for stock in the Company. The minimum investment was £12 10s 0d for one share, whilst individuals who purchased two or more shares gained additional privileges in the form of membership of an 'inner council' (5); which in 1609 consisted of fifty-two members.

By 1612 the Virginia project was again beset by huge difficulties both in Virginia and also by the Company's rapidly deteriorating financial position in England. Hence a Third Charter, dated 12th March 1612, was drawn up to bring in additional shareholders to the project. Over three hundred new backers' names were added. This Third Charter also extended the powers of both the Company and, in particular, individual investors in matters of private land ownerships in Virginia and any profits that might be gained from the development of holdings of this nature. (6)



London Virginia Company seal.

The Leicestershire Investors

Although the 1609 Charter names over 650 individuals as shareholders, there appears to be only one investor with a birth link to Leicestershire; albeit perhaps a tenuous one to an obscure family in the north of the county. This investor is George Bolles, born in 1538, who Phillimore describes as a member of the Grocers Company and as 'the son of Thomas Bolles of Newbold (Co. Leics)' (7), his mother being Jane Winter, a member of the Winter family of Worthington in north Leicestershire. Bolles was in fact Master of the Grocers Company in 1606 and Sheriff of London in 1608-9 at the time of the Second Virginia Charter. He went on to become Lord Mayor of London around his eightieth year and was knighted during his mayoralty. By this time however, Bolles' Leicestershire links were probably overshadowed by his links to Lincolnshire where he had acquired a mansion and estates at Scampton through marriage to a wealthy widow, Joan Gates. He died in 1621 and was buried at St Swithins Church, London.

In contrast to the situation in 1609, the Third Charter of 1612 produced several links with prominent Leicestershire families. Among the new Leicestershire names on the 1612 Charter was Henry Hastings, 5th Earl of Huntingdon, considered to be the leading political figure in Leicestershire in the early seventeenth century. Although his role in

national politics was potentially limited by financial difficulties, this did not deter him from speculating in the new settlement. He was known to be on amicable terms with prominent Virginia supporters such as the Earls of Southampton and Pembroke, and became a substantial backer of the Virginia project, paying £220 (over £25,000 in today's money) in return for 1,000 acres of land in the new Virginia Plantation (8). He remained however in England himself, giving power of attorney to two persons to act as agents for his interests in Virginia. The two men were Nicolas Martiau, born in France of a Huguenot family, and Benjamin Blewett. The two travelled to Virginia aboard the *Francis Bonaventure* in spring 1620. Little seems to be known about Blewett, but Martiau's fortunes in Virginia prospered. He became a substantial landowner and, through the marriage of his daughter, Elizabeth, to Colonel George Reade, he is now counted among the earliest American ancestors of George Washington, his great-great-great-grandson.

Another investor with strong Leicestershire connections was Sir William Herrick of Beaumanor, who was a member of the Goldsmiths Livery Company, being its Prime Warden in 1605. Herrick had personal experience of overseas travel, having been sent as a diplomat to Turkey by Queen Elizabeth I. (9) By the time of his investment in Virginia in 1612 he would have been in his mid-fifties. Although his main home was near Richmond (Surrey), he had purchased the Beaumanor estate in 1595 and married Joan May the following year. (10) Herrick's fortunes prospered under James I as the new monarch made him both court jeweller and a Teller of the Exchequer. Apparently undaunted by the lack of return on the family's Virginia investment, one of William's sons, Henry, continued the family interest in the New World by emigrating to New England in 1629.

The Herrick marriage link with the May family led to a further Leicestershire connection with the Virginia enterprise. Sir Humfrey May was another new name on the 1612 Charter and is also shown on a list of shareholders published in 1620. Four years later in June 1624, May, as Chancellor of the Duchy of Lancaster, became one of the fourteen members of the Commission deputed to look at the problems of Virginia that led to the dissolution of the Company and to Virginia becoming a Crown Colony. (11) Though descended from a Sussex family, May was elected MP for Leicestershire in the 1624 and 1625 Parliaments. (12)

The splendid twenty-one panelled stained glass window above the main oak staircase of the current Beaumanor house depicts not only the coats of arms of Sir William Herrick and Sir Humfrey May, but also in the upper panel, the arms of another Virginia investor, Sir Baptist Hicks.

Sir Baptist Hicks' link to the Herricks was through his marriage to another daughter of the May family, Elizabeth. Hicks himself came from a successful line of Mercers and was among the prominent investors on the 1609 Charter, where he is shown as a Council Member. In common with Sir Robert Herrick, Hicks was considered to be one of England's wealthiest citizens at this time and is perhaps now best associated with the Gloucestershire wool town of Chipping Campden, in whose parish church he is buried. It could possibly have been through the May family links, that both Sir Humfrey May and Sir Robert Herrick were introduced to the investment opportunities in Virginia.

Two further 1612 investors with Leicestershire roots came from the Beaumont family. One was Sir Thomas Beaumont (1555-1614), the third son of Sir Nicholas of Coleorton. Through his marriage to Catherine Farnham of Stoughton, Thomas gained the Manor of Stoughton, which remained in the Beaumont family until 1737. He was knighted in 1603 and there is a memorial to him in St Mary and All Saints Stoughton, where one of the bells is inscribed with his name. Thomas made frequent, but not always profitable, investment forays into the North Warwickshire coal industry together with similar ventures in Leicestershire,

Nottinghamshire and as far away as Northumberland.

The second Beaumont was John Beaumont, second son of Sir Francis of Gracedieu. John had become head of this branch of the family in 1605. John and his younger brother, Francis, were both prominent members of London's early seventeenth century literary circle, and close friends of the Warwickshire (Hartshill near Nuneaton)-born poet Michael Drayton, whose *Ode to Virginia*, penned on the departure of the 1607 adventurers, reflects the optimism surrounding the initial voyage. John also had strong recusant leanings and connections, which, at the time of the 1609 Charter, confined him to restrict his movements to within five miles of his Gracedieu residence. By 1610 he was allowed to re-visit London and re-join the literary group that frequented the Mermaid Tavern and included both Michael Drayton and Ben Jonson. John later enjoyed a role as a court poet, thanks to the Beaumonts' inter-marriage link with another Leicestershire family, the Villiers. (13) Described as one of the 'outstanding pioneer coalmining families of the age' (14), speculation in Virginia's potential, but at this stage unknown, mineral wealth, may have been the Beaumont family's motive for investment.



Beaumanor Hall, Leicestershire, stained glass window depicting the arms of Sir William Herrick, Sir Humfrey May and Sir Baptist Hicks. (With acknowledgement to Caroline Wessel, Portrait of Beaumanor, Herricks and Beaumanor Society, 1988.)

A female member of another branch of the Beaumont family, Anne Beaumont, also produces a link with one of the most mysterious and intriguing of all Virginia investors, Sir Christopher Perkins. Perkins is described as a 'diplomat' in the *Oxford Dictionary of Biography*, but his career, comprising membership of the Jesuit fraternity before turning informant to Walsingham and Cecil, has the characteristics of a late sixteenth century James Bond. By the early seventeenth century, Perkins was not only a Member of Parliament for Morpeth, but clearly part of Robert Cecil's 'network'. He is listed as a 1609 investor and described as Dean of Carlisle. He married Anne, daughter of Anthony Beaumont of Glenfield in 1617, possibly attracted to the family by ambition. Anne's sister, Mary Villiers was the mother of George, Duke of Buckingham, whose stature in Court was very much in the ascendancy in 1617. (15)



William Wollaston's memorial at Shenton church.

A further investor with Leicestershire links who first appears on the 1612 Charter is William Wollaston. In 1612 Wollaston had more direct links with his native Staffordshire, and did not make Leicestershire his major domicile until 1625 when he purchased the manor of Shenton from Sir Richard Molineux. (16) The extent of Wollaston's wealth, based on his early coal-mining interests in North Leicestershire, is still amply demonstrated today in the form of the splendid Shenton Hall that he built in 1629, (although now with considerable later improvements). Wollaston himself lived to see the post-Restoration period, he died on the 10th December 1666 at the age of 86 and is commemorated in St John's Church Shenton.

A later addition to the list of Virginia investors with a Leicestershire link is Theodore Goulston. Born in 1572, his roots were in Wymondham, where his father was Vicar. After studying at Merton College, Oxford, he moved to London in 1606 and entered Gray's Inn. However, his interest in legal matters seems to have been overtaken by one in medical affairs, and he returned to his native

Wymondham to practice as a medical man. He rapidly obtained a medical degree from his old College in Oxford, and on 22nd December 1610 was admitted to the College of Physicians, going on to obtain a Fellowship of the College on 29th December 1611. (17) He returned to London, where his medical reputation soon became a formidable one, especially it seems, after when in 1614, he was credited with saving the life of the Archbishop of Canterbury, George Abbott. His interest in Virginia may have arisen from both his known meetings with representatives of the Algonquin Indians who visited London around 1616, and his professional relationships with Virginia investors such as George Abbott and Sir Edwin Sandys. Goulston had also successfully treated Sandys in 1614, and his grateful patient had rewarded him by enabling his election as a free brother of the East India Company. (18) In 1619 Sandys became Treasurer of the Virginia Company and in December 1619 Goulston bought a substantial holding of six shares from various sources in the Company. (19) Within months he became a Council Member of the Company and was consulted by the Company about the suitability of Dr Pott for appointment as physician-general for Virginia in 1621. Goulston's successful medical practice earned him substantial wealth and investments, and in his will he endowed a scholarship to the College of Physicians and the Goulstonian Lecture remains an annual feature of that College.

A further Leicestershire link with the Virginia Company occurs through the work of John Brinsley, headmaster of Ashby Grammar School. Brinsley came to Ashby in 1600 and his work on educational delivery techniques, first published in 1612, attracted much interest, including that of the Virginia Company. Brinsley produced a further report in 1621 especially for the Virginia Company, which, by that time, was formulating plans to create a college and school in the settlement. (20) Brinsley is not known to have been an investor and nothing further seems to have come of the project, probably as a result of the 1622 massacre in Virginia (21), and by that time, the Company's ever-deepening financial crisis and corrosive internal dissensions.

By the terms of the Third Charter of 1612, the Company was allowed by the King the privilege of organising lotteries throughout England as a further means of raising finance for the enterprise. (22) It is recorded that Henry Hastings, 5th Earl of Huntingdon also took an active interest in the Company's attempts to find settlers. (23) Therefore, it seems quite possible that Huntingdon may well have had a hand in bringing the Virginia Company lottery to the streets of Leicester. The records of the Borough of Leicester contain one of the few direct references to the conduct of one of the Virginia Company's Lotteries in May 1618 in 'the towne of Leicester', aimed at 'the advancement of that most noble and Christian Plantation which wee now have great hope and

greater than heretofore, shall stand and flourishe to the honor of God, the benefit of his Realme and the enlargement of His Majesties Domyions'. (24)

The fall of the Virginia Company

By about 1620 the Company was able to take some financial comfort from the export of tobacco back to England as a means of producing revenue, although the King was averse to "that outlandish weed" and the issue of tobacco and health was raised in the Chamber of the House of Commons as early as 1621. (25) Even so, the Company was in serious financial difficulties, with unpaid dividends and the increased use of lotteries making potential investors wary, whilst the Company debt was now over £9,000 (well over £1 million in today's values). There was also a great rift within the Company with two rival factions both vying for control and pursuing quite different aims in the development of the Company; one, fronted by the Puritan-sympathising Sir Edwines Sandys aiming for settlement, the other, consisting of powerful merchants purely interested in speculation and profitable trade.

On the 24th June 1624 an order in Council set up a special commission to investigate the problems of the Virginia Company. The Council comprised fourteen members, among them was Sir Humphrey May in his capacity as Chancellor of the Duchy of Lancaster. The Council recommended the dissolution of the Company and the 'takeover' of the Virginia enterprise by the Crown in the form of a royal colony.

The eighteen years of the Company had perhaps ended in failure, but as Anderson remarks, the foundations laid by the early Virginia settlers and investors, though with considerable difficulties and sacrifices, provided the base for later economic growth in the Chesapeake area. On the other hand, back in England, the actions of the Sandys-led faction in the latter stages of the Company may be seen as among the first seeds of the increasing dissension between some influential members of English Society and the Crown that would become increasingly apparent in the next two decades leading to the Civil War.

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